scandal blown over, than a new embarrassment appeared in early 1978, courtesy of the West German weekly Der Spiegel, which announced with glaring headlines that it had obtained an ‘opposition manifesto’ from a group in the GDR called the ‘Bundes Demokratischer Kommunisten Deutschlands’ (BDKD).

Although there was plenty of scepticism about this hitherto unknown movement – said to be made up of ‘high and mid-level functionaries’ – the magazine published the entire manifesto, crammed with bruising allegations and indelicate wording. Over the course of two editions on January 2 and 9, it accused SED leaders of living in ‘golden ghettos’ built in the forests and guarded like fortresses. Readers were enthralled by accusations that the SED hierarchy were shamelessly corrupted and enriched themselves in special stores with private imports from the West. Leaders were showered with ‘decorations, bonuses, special clinics, pensions and presents’. No less startling, it caustically remarked that no ruling class of Germany had ever ‘sponged so much as those two dozen families who run our country like a self-service store’.

Spread over thirty pages, the full manifesto presented a formidable list of complaints, including, among other things:

We ask: did the working-class fight for supporting an immense host of good-for-nothing parasites in the party apparatus? Did it fight to make a life at the expense of the state treasury possible for these ML [Marxism-Leninism] preachers? Did it fight to achieve the fact that despite the Council of Ministers’ decision on the reduction of the apparatus, year after year the state administration keeps growing, growing, growing? And all that even though a dozen computers would suffice to set 100,000 administrators free for bitterly needed services?

Honecker himself, repeatedly and loudly, announced better living conditions in the service sector. Waiting periods for repairs of household equipment in some cases have increased threefold. Gas and electric stoves, circulation pumps, washing machines, vacuum cleaners, or refrigerators